

CATHOLIC THEOLOGICAL ASSOCIATION OF NIGERIA



VADEMECUM FOR ELECTORS IN NIGERIA

MANUAL FOR RESPONSIBLE
CITIZENSHIP ACCORDING TO
CATHOLIC SOCIAL TEACHING

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VADEMECUM FOR ELECTORS IN NIGERIA

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We can truly say this booklet is a joint effort of the members. Finally, we are grateful to Most Revd Anselm Umoren, MSP, the Auxiliary Bishop of the Catholic Archdiocese of Abuja, for going through

the final draft, in order to give the imprimatur.

May the Lord bless this act of our ministry as theologians and pastors for the sake of birthing a new politically engaged generation that might have 'a different spirit' from the previous generations – a generation that might be more fully alive, more reconciled. May our land reach the Promised Land of Loving Justice, Peace, and Reconciliation that we have been groping and struggling towards.

Our Lady, Queen of Nigeria – Pray for us!

INTRODUCTION

The words of John Courtney Murray, an American Jesuit and moral theologian, resonate for the intelligentsia, activists, and the youths in Nigeria today:

As a public philosophy, the American consensus needs to be constantly argued. If the public argument dies from disinterest, or subsides into the angry mutterings of polemic, or rises to the shrillness of hysteria, or trails off into positivistic triviality, or gets lost in a morass of semantics, you may be sure that the barbarian is at the gates of the city.¹

The fierce urgency of now demands that we confront the barbarian at the gates of our nation space.

What do we do? A deceased Pan-African activist in the civil rights movement, Dr Tajudeen Abdul-Raheem, used to sign

off his emails: “Don’t agonise, Organise!”²

As Nigeria inches towards the next general elections, and in the light of recent nationwide experiences of angst, members of the Catholic Theological Association of Nigeria (CATHAN), at their annual Conference in April 2018, resolved to move beyond agonising about the current state of the nation. We determined to start organising.

As theologians, as pastoral agents, and as leaders of thought, what remains to clearly articulate in our distressed yet opportune context is *who*, *what* and *how* to organise in a way that is faithful to the twin pillars of Catholic Social Thought, on one hand, and the history of Church’s political engagement from antiquity³, on the other.

Where do we start, going forward from the annual conference? As good citizens, aware of our civic responsibility, the scriptural injunctions to be good citizens (1 Pt 2:15-17) become a call for

proactive interventions. Hence, we determined to provide a vademecum for the electorate since they are pivotal to who wins or loses elections.

This Voters’ guide helps to navigate the frosty political clime under which we exist and hope to conduct future elections. We aim at ensuring that the electorate, especially Christians, truly understand the issues, and see their social and political engagement as a vocation to bring about a better world, in which the least as well as the great are equally protected under the law.

This document provides helpful criteria for Christians to make informed and conscientious choices when voting. This is because a “well formed Christian conscience does not permit one to vote for a political party or an individual law that contradicts the fundamental contents of faith and morals.”⁴ A well-formed Christian conscience in turn shapes and influences how Christians contribute to civil and respectful public dialogue and po-

litical choices in the year of elections.⁵ This is a call to discipleship in the world of politics, which is a civic means ensuring equitable distribution of the common good, while guaranteeing both civic and religious virtues.

CATHAN's position was firmly taught many years ago by the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria (CBCN), when it issued an auspicious public document⁶ during a general election cycle. It states in part: "the exercise of one's responsible citizenship is itself a function of one's Christian commitment."⁷ Accordingly, Christians ought to bring their faith and their Christian morality to bear in political debates and to inform decisions about candidates and moral issues in the light of Catholic social tradition.⁸

Our faith and politics are not antithetical. In fact, both should be mutually supportive. Through civic and political engagement, responsible citizens contribute to our commonwealth and prosperity. And our "[n]ational unity and

prosperity can be, and should be part of the building of the kingdom of God."⁹

Accordingly, this document has been designed to be a politico-theological reflection and update of the 1979 CBCN teaching. We, therefore, offer our people a tool that conscientises, informs, and directs them regarding their roles in the political arena, especially during the electioneering period.

Given that there are neither Catholic nor Christian parties anywhere in Nigeria, Catholic/Christian electors and Catholics who have embraced politics as a vocation, need a guide on what to look for in political parties and candidates seeking their votes from the perspectives of Catholic Social Thought.

We are confident that this document offers a framework and indices for responsible electorate. Let us set sail, ready to cast into the deep. By this, Nigerians demonstrate that they are ready to *stop agonising*, and are *organising*.

Revd Dr Raymond Olusesan Aina, MSP
*President, Catholic Theological Association of
Nigeria,
August 29, 2018,
The Beheading of John the Baptist*

PREAMBLE

Nigeria, a Blessed Nation

1. Nigeria as a nation is blessed and richly endowed with both human and natural resources. We thank God for His immense love and for the gift of faith in our various religious affiliations.
2. The Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria 1999 (As Amended) guarantees all citizens the “freedom of thought, conscience and religion, including the freedom ... to manifest and propagate (his) our religion or belief in worship, teaching, practice and observance” (S. 38(1)). The same Constitution guarantees “freedom of expression, including freedom to hold opinions and to receive

and impart ideas and information without interference” (S. 39(1)), and the freedom also to disseminate the same information, ideas and opinions (S. 39(2)). These freedoms are secured by the fundamental freedom of every person “to assemble freely and associate with other persons, and in particular he may form or belong to any political party, trade union or any other association for the protection of his interests...” (S. 40). Over and above these specific freedoms, we invoke the International Code of Human Rights and its associated freedoms germane to the dignity of human persons. These underpin the resilient hope we nourish as a people – ‘One Nation bound in Freedom, Peace and Unity’ – and the desire we harbour for a peaceful forthcoming electioneering season.¹

1

PRESENT FEARS AND ANXIETIES

3. At this time in our history, our country is plagued with many and varied problems. Despite gaining independence nearly 60 years ago, and despite huge natural resource endowments in almost every part of the country, Nigeria is still considered a “disastrous development experience.”² Compared to countries that are blessed with similar human and natural resources, Nigeria should be a real giant! Unfortunately, our country is judged to be no better than a mere developmental toddler, lagging behind in almost all development indices.

4. It is a fundamental imperative for government to formulate and implement policies and programmes that will enhance the right of every person and association to participate actively in the shaping of the community and in promoting the general well-being of all, especially the vulnerable and the poor. Our experience, however, is that Nigerians are still struggling with the basic means of livelihood like shelter, accessible and affordable health care, education, potable water, good road network, electricity and other functional social services.³ The country is further plagued with terrorism, militant herdsman, cattle rustling and displacement of ethnic populations on account of violence. In all of these challenges, Nigerians have not seen decisive steps taken by the government to address the insecurity that is their daily experience, and stem the obvious slow descent into chaos.

5. Youth unemployment, at the current rate, is unprecedented in Nigeria. The teeming unemployed youth population has risen steadily over several years, and there are hardly convincing efforts to address what is now being referred to a waiting time-bomb. There are many who think that the burgeoning population of unemployed youth constitutes very grave danger in the face of the upcoming election season. These youth could easily become willing tools in the hands of unscrupulous politicians to be deployed to carry out various electoral malpractices, which could further worsen the country's security challenges.

6. The unhealthy rivalry between the three tiers and arms of government is another threat to democracy itself, and to the corporate existence of the country. Corruption in all its forms, impunity of government agents and

officials, and their favoured associates, at different levels of society threaten the collapse of the social fabric of Nigeria. The common practice of persecution of political opponents, blatant service of or naked appeals to tribalism and other forms of discriminatory partiality have created an atmosphere of mutual distrust all over the country.⁴

7. In recent times too, Nigerian Christians have witnessed a subtle yet potent assault on their religion; arising from disparate policies and actions of Government in public service, education and the judiciary.⁵ These policies and actions seem to favour Islam over Christianity. Furthermore, it would seem, in the view of many, that Government decision-making is, in general, skewed in favour of one ethnic group. This interference in religious as well as civic matters by the Government, without due regard to the ethnic and religious sensitivities,

whether overt or covert, is strange to our Constitution! Many Nigerians now fear that the emasculation of Christianity and ethnic Christians through Government policy may, sooner or later, degenerate into a rehash of the religious and ethnic hostilities of the past civil war, and imperil the hard-earned unity of the country.

8. These challenges are at the heart of public life and at the centre of the pursuit of the common good. It is imperative therefore to make them top burners in political debates which would lead to informed decisions in the choice of electoral candidates.⁶

2

**THE HUMAN PERSON AS
THE CHURCH'S CENTRAL
CONCERN**

9. All the fears and anxieties enumerated above, and many more that are emerging on a daily basis, are human problems. Bearing in mind that the Church is an expert in humanity,⁷ it is only natural that she is not only well-placed, but also has the right and duty to address these problems, even in our time and in our country, Nigeria. While avoiding partisan contestations of political gains, “the Church has never failed... to speak the words that are hers with regard to questions concerning life in society... in order to sustain and foster the activity of Christians in the social sector, especially the activity

of the lay faithful to whom this area belongs in a particular way....”⁸

10. These statements arise from, and point to, the Church's fundamental belief in the social and communitarian nature of the human person. The Fathers of the Second Vatican Council already spoke of life in society as not being “something accessory to man himself: through his dealings with others, through mutual service, and through fraternal dialogue, man develops all his talents and becomes able to rise to his destiny.”⁹ The political community constitutes one of the social ties necessary for the full development of the human person. This is as much a human reality as it is to belong to a family. Thus, “the Church wishes to help form consciences in political life and to stimulate greater insight into the authentic requirement of justice as well as greater readiness to act

accordingly, even when this might involve conflict with situations of personal interest.”¹⁰

Key Principles to bear in Mind

11. Very fundamental to our decision making in the public life are certain principles that are derived from the scripture, Catholic moral and social teaching and natural law that are engraved in the hearts of people of goodwill. We should, therefore, be guided by these moral imperatives rather than our attachment to political party or interest group. There should be a positive synergy between our moral principles and our political choices, our values and our votes, in order to help in building a just and a better world. For over a hundred years, the Church has sought to apply the values of the Gospel to societal problems with the aim of helping its members to participate actively

in the task of building a just and compassionate social order.¹¹ The Church is therefore calling for a new form of political engagement that is influenced and shaped by this positive synergy.¹² The following principles are key to understanding the Church’s approach:

a. The Dignity of the Human Person

Created in the image and likeness of God (Gn 1:27), the human person is established as the pinnacle of creation. For this reason, “the human individual possesses the dignity of a person, who is not just something, but someone.”¹³ By implication, humans will ever remain God’s image, with a sacred dignity and a permanent link between God and humanity.

Another basis for human dignity is the fact of being created free by God and being endowed with free will/freedom. This freedom however, is not a permissive licence for us to act outside the com-

mand of divine injunction. By the virtue of God taking on our nature, we are challenged to see every member of the human race as a sacrament of God's presence amongst us.

Thus, whatever we do to the least member of the human race is done to God (cf. Mt 25). If this is taken as seriously as it should, all considerations of politics and the social arrangements that follow from them, should place the human person at the centre, and seek what is best for him/her without destroying her/his essence and connection with God. Any development that fosters this dignity must be considered good, just as actions of the state, overt or covert, that denigrate, erode or deny this dignity are evil. John Paul II warned about the contagious nature of these evil actions or obstacles to the process of the development of peoples.¹⁴

The actions and attitudes enumerated above do not only cause fear and anxiety

among citizens; they are also opposed to the will of God and the good of neighbour. In our present situation, structures have arisen, which seem to be designed to achieve two goals, namely, "on the one hand, the all-consuming desire for profit, and on the other, the thirst for power, with the intention of imposing ones will upon others... 'at any price'."¹⁵

None of these, needless to say, promotes the dignity of the human person. It is pertinent therefore to respect and protect life itself. It is also on the basis of this that everything in nature and policies (social, economic and scientific advancement) should be at the service of the human person and not the contrary.¹⁶

b. The Common Good at Stake

The common Good is the anchor "to which every aspect of social life must be related if it is to attain its fullest meaning."¹⁷ The Vatican II Council Fathers define it as "the sum total of social con-

ditions which allow people, either as groups or as individuals, to reach their fulfilment more fully and more easily.”¹⁸

A single social condition is not applicable everywhere. No! Since human beings are creative and created in freedom, they can bring about, and subsist in, a variety of social conditions as may prevail at any given time. This is why the common good could be described more comprehensively as a network of social conditions which enable human individuals and groups to flourish and live fully, genuine human lives.

Its three essential elements include: respect for the human person, pursuing the social wellbeing and development of the social group and creating the conditions for overall peace.¹⁹ The *Catechism* further states that to serve “the common good” requires that “citizens fulfil their roles in the life of the political community” (CCC, 2239).

In politics as in economics, there are both supply and demand sides. The for-

mer has to do with those who are seeking to be, or have been, entrusted with the responsibility of governance, whether at the legislative, executive or the judiciary to deliver all that it takes to build and uphold the common good in the society. The latter, on the other hand, includes the honest aspirations and concrete demands of citizens for what it takes to build the common good, and their legitimate expectation to be participants in that project.

The politics that aims at creating a common good does not, therefore, admit of bystanders or observers! It is a common and public action that requires every person to work together to achieve. There arises, therefore, a social contract between voters and candidates seeking elective positions, where voters vote only those who will promote the common good and the social wellbeing of all citizens. In this regard, Christians seeking elective office should consider it an ex-

tension of Jesus' commission to "feed my lambs... tend my sheep" (Jn 21:15-16).

Following the principle of subsidiarity, all the three levels of government recognised by the Constitution should be alive to their responsibilities, which should never be usurped by a higher level. The government should ensure that the rights of individuals, families and organizations are respected, as a mark of the realisation of the common good. The exploitation of religious freedom to disguise hidden interests such as the subversion of the established order, the hoarding of resources or the grabbing of power by a single group, are all against this value, and can cause enormous harm to the very foundations of society.

c. The Value and Obligation of Participation

Participation is at the core of the realisation of the common good. It is not enough for one individual or group, however well-equipped, to saddle itself

with procuring the common good on behalf of everybody else. All are invited to work for it, and must be given every opportunity to participate in it, both as contributors as well as beneficiaries.

The active participation of citizens in the electioneering process, including the possibility of voting and being voted for, in a free, fair and credible contest is a value to be cultivated and encouraged. It is also an obligation whose fulfilment is a good indication of a society that is built upon, and respecting of, the common good. By their votes, citizens have the right and corresponding responsibility to determine the candidates who would govern them.

Consequently, Christians are morally obliged to promote this common good,²⁰ by voting for the right candidates. The conscientious exercise of the right mentioned here relies to a large extent on how well formed the consciences of the electorates are. The formation of consciences is a lifetime project, and this Guide is a

small contribution to it, with regard to elections.

As *bona fide* citizens of Nigeria, Christians have the same constitutional rights and duties as everyone else to participate actively in public life. It is in this light that Nigerian Bishops reiterate the teaching of the Council Fathers that it accords with human nature "that juridical-political structures should, with ever better success and without any discrimination, afford all their citizens the chance to participate freely and actively in establishing the constitutional bases of determining political community, governing the state, determining the scope and purpose of various institutions and choosing leaders. Hence, let all citizens be mindful of their simultaneous right and duty to vote freely in the interest of advancing the common good."²¹

The *Catechism of Catholic Church* also lends credence to the Catholic Bishops of Nigeria's assertion on active participation in politics in this pronouncement: "It

is necessary that all participate, each according to his position and role, in promoting the common good. Obligation is inherent in the dignity of the human person. ... As far as possible, citizens should take active part in public life."²² Being actively involved in the electoral process is to the mind of the Nigerian bishops a demand of patriotism, an important religious virtue of piety. True piety is tantamount to respectful and responsible devotedness both to one's familial father, God and one's fatherland.²³

Our refusal to actively participate in the electoral process, pose great danger to our ability to truly practice and carry out our mission or contribute to the common good, thus we might be forced to sacrifice our faith, our fundamental teachings and moral principles. Thus, the Catholic Bishops of Nigeria enjoin all to be active participants in the electoral process: "It is the noble right and serious duty of every responsible citizen to do what he can towards the establishment,

maintenance and successful operation of a good government...everyone with the right to vote does have the opportunity, which should be exercised responsibly, to help form, mandate and direct his government."²⁴

d. Fundamental Option for the Poor and Vulnerable

Preferential concern must be accorded the weak and vulnerable members of the larger society (the marginalised, unborn children, terminally ill, persons with disability, the elderly and victims of injustice and oppression). This preferential option is rooted in Jesus' concern for the weak and vulnerable members of the society of his era.

The substance of our Christian calling is visible in our relationship with, and attitude to, the most vulnerable members of the society. The importance of the relationship with the vulnerable members of the human race is so central that the last judgement and where we shall spend

eternity are based on it (cf. Mt 25:31-46). To buttress this imperative the *Catechism* declares: "Those who are oppressed by poverty are the objects of a preferential love on the part of the Church which, since her origin and in spite of the failings of many of her members, has not ceased to work for their relief, defense, and liberation through numerous works of charity which remain indispensable always and everywhere."²⁵

e. Subsidiarity

The principle of subsidiarity projects the primary relationships in society to be those of family and small social groups. It is from here that larger social groups like nations and governments are formed. According to the Church's understanding, it would be gravely wrong "to take from individuals what they can accomplish by their own initiative and industry and give it to the community, so also it is an injustice and at the same time a grave evil and disturbance of right order to assign

to a greater and higher association what lesser and subordinate organizations can do. For every social activity ought of its very nature to furnish help to the members of the body social, and never destroy or absorb them."²⁶

This restraint from interfering with and absorbing smaller bodies does not mean neglecting these bodies in cases of injustice or unjust aggression. The larger bodies like the government must hasten to the assistance of smaller groups in times of crises and when their rights are violated. True federalism is based on this principle, and it remains a "grave evil and disturbance of right order" for a federal government to usurp the rights of state governments, for states to usurp those of local governments, as we see in Nigeria today.

f. Dignity of Work and the Right of Workers

Economic policies must be at the service of human being. The dignity of work

rests on the fact that work is a call to participate in the divine act of creation. Employers of labour make direct contribution to the common good through the provision of products and services, especially when they create employment that enhances human dignity and rights of workers to productive work, to decent and just wages, to adequate benefits and security in old age, freedom of association (unionism) private property and economic initiative.²⁷

Employed labourers also have corresponding duties and responsibilities to provide a fair day's work for a fair day's pay, respect employers and co-workers and carry out their jobs in a way that will promote the common good. Employers and the employed and union must jointly work not just for self-interest but for the advancement of economic justice and well-being of everyone.

Political Vocation and Political Virtues

12. Christians have dual citizenship; they belong to the community of faith. This community of faith has its own unique values and ethos. Christians are therefore to practice and live out these values in their day to day active. Christians are also members of territorial geographical sovereignty that makes constitutional demands on its citizens. Christians can ill-afford to be actively involved in public or political life because of the consequences that political policies and decisions may have on their social well-being, their salvation and their call to evangelise and witness to the truth of the Gospel.

On the strength of the foregoing, the Church has a moral duty to be actively involved in the shaping of the society. This is a requirement for self-preservation and of faith. We are

called to Christian charity of love of our neighbours (Jn 13.34) and because we are people of faith and reason there is the need for us to bring our convictions and values about human life and dignity to bear on the public life candidates.²⁸ In the words of Benedict XVI, the call to promote the well-being of the human person “must be animate the entire lives of the lay faithful and therefore also their political activity, lived as ‘social charity’.”²⁹

13. The Christian’s involvement in politics arises out of the obligation to make disciples of all nations by teaching about moral values capable of influencing public life for good. Christians also have constitutional duties and obligations to participate in society. The Church also needs to participate in the life of the society because of the important asset that it is to political dialogue. The society also stands to gain from the Church’s

experience in ministering to the homeless, assistance to women with challenges, feeding the hungry and promoting social justice and peace.

Prudence as a Political Virtue

14. Prudence, according to the *Catechism*, is the virtue that enables us “to discern our true good in every circumstance and to choose the right means of achieving it” (no. 1806). It is an important virtue that Christians must develop as they navigate the political terrain that is often laden with great deception and lack of transparency. There is therefore the need to exercise caution in considering the various political options that are present before them. Christians are called to courageously choose options that are in line with the moral principles taught by the Church’s magisterium that are most fitting to every specific situation, if they have to make decisions on how

to build a sustainable society of justice and peace.

The need to exhibit the virtue of prudence within the political sphere arises from the fact that the good end does not necessarily justify any means. Thus, we must prudently make a distinction between public policies that are in line with Christian’s moral tenets and those inimical to them. While Christians may hold different opinions on social problems, it must never be lost on them in the course of building a just and peaceful world that every opinion held must be within Christian moral principles. Every means adopted to address societal problems and every policy formulated or economic programme adopted must conform to acceptable moral dictates that take cognisance of inviolable human dignity and respect and protection of human life.

15. Proverbs 4.14 enjoins believers not to set their feet on the path of evildoers. 1 Peter 3.11 calls on them to turn from evil and embrace the good. "Do good and avoid Evil." Christians are confronted with the daily dilemma of having to choose between good and evil choices especially within the political arena. It must be reemphasised that there are certain actions or choices that they must never choose because such choices are inimical to our obligation to love God and our neighbours. There are core evil choices that are abhorrent to Christian's consciences that are often promoted in the political arena; Christians are call to be vigilant in discerning where prospective candidates for elective positions stand in relation to these intrinsic evil. These evil are directly opposed to our profession of love of God and neighbour and are always opposed to the authentic good of the human persons. These must be detected,

opposed, rejected and exposed wherever they are found.

In view of this, we must avoid actions that are deeply flawed and are opposed to the dignity of the human person or the authentic good of the human person. Such flawed actions are wilful taking human life that is sacred, genocide, abortion, euthanasia, embezzlement of funds meant for poverty alleviation or pension scheme or for the provision of needed and necessary basic social infrastructures and services.³⁰

16. Life should not be reduced to individual choice and laws that violate basic human rights should not be enacted. These evil actions have serious moral, physical and emotional consequences on the human person and the society in which he lives. The avoidance of evil actions implies that one embraces positive or good actions. As Pope John Paul II opined "The fact that only

the negative commandments oblige always and under all circumstances does not mean that the moral life prohibitions are more important than the obligation to do good indicated by the positive commandment.”³¹

In carrying out our duties and obligations within the political arena and in making decisions on candidates or issues to support within the political context, Christians must have recourse to the fundamental moral principles taught by the magisterium on such issues and where prospective candidates for elective posts also stand. They must consider the levels of their commitment and fidelity to the Christian’s moral dictates in respect of the dignity of the human person, sacredness and sanctity of human life, moral imperative to respond to the needs of neighbours, provision of basic needs such as food, shelter, health care, education and meaningful work.³²

3

SOME ISSUES THAT CHRISTIANS SHOULD KEEP IN MIND IN EXERCISING THEIR VOTES

Non-Negotiable Issues

17. As Christians, we are acutely aware of a set of values that are at the foundation of life itself, for “Democracy must be based on the true and solid foundation of non-negotiable ethical principles, which are underpinning of the life of the society.”³³ These ethical principles are meant to protect human life and dignity from conception to natural end. They are non-negotiable because the actions that negate them are intrinsically evil, not just for individual persons, but for the right ordering of society as a whole. Therefore, in a well

ordered society, no law may validly support such actions such as abortion, euthanasia, medical experimentation with embryonic stem cells or artificial reproductive technologies, e.g. in vitro fertilisation. Furthermore, though we do not stand as judges over our brethren, Christians must be wary of candidates who speak and act like they would, if elected, abrogate the 2013 Same-Sex Marriage Prohibition Law. Not only is this activity against our cultural sensibilities, it also negatively affects our social organisation. Thus, Christians must examine candidates and their manifestoes according to these non-negotiable moral values before voting. Our democratic enterprise must bear out our social formation, emanating from African humanism, for “Only a humanism open to the Absolute can guide us in the promotion and building of forms of social and civic life - structures, institutions, culture and ethos -

without exposing us to the risk of becoming ensnared by the fashions of the moment.”³⁴

Threat to life

18. Every form of threat to the human life must be opposed such as abortion, euthanasia or intentional taking of human life on any ground. These are threats and violation of human dignity and such are direct attack of life itself.

Unequal Religious Privileges and Absence of Freedom of Religion

19. Other intrinsic evil actions that must be exposed and resisted are the relegation of Christian teaching/doctrines in the education sector, lack of freedom to practice one's religion belief/faith under a safe and conducive environment. Another is the intentional promotion and

preferential treatment accorded a particular religion to the disadvantage of other religion beliefs and religious bigotry. These are real threats to our corporate existence as a nation.

4

IMPORTANT ISSUES FOR NIGERIAN VOTERS

20. *Religious Freedom* – Religious freedom is a fundamental human right, that is, a right that we have simply by being human persons. This can be expressed as two sides of one coin. Negatively, it means the absence of coercion to practice a religion of one's choosing. Positively, it implies that society creates conditions where religious expression can flourish. This should be the case for individuals as well as for families, groups and organisations. Pope Francis expresses this idea well when he insists that the Church must have "the freedom and all the means needed to bring the proclamation of the Kingdom to the existential peripheries of society."³⁵ Every Christian should,

therefore, ensure that they cast their votes for candidates and parties that will guarantee, protect and support the freedom of religion for all citizens, and shall equally allow the People of God to express their faith publicly, and without hindrance.

21. *Peace and Security* – On account of our multi-ethnic, multi-religious society, Nigerians are prone to competition for social and political relevance. This is often a source of tension, which often escalates into actual socio-political unrest. With Nigeria's growing population, having to share resources, which are not growing in the same proportion, means that this competition will grow ever fiercer going forward. In this situation, the Church's stand that "Peace is the work of justice and the effect of charity"³⁶ becomes even more critical. In order to ensure peace Nigeria needs a government that is ready to facilitate a dialogue process that will ensure the

equitable distribution of the nation's resources, and address the discontents among different sections of the country. Fostering peace "demands the absolute and radical rejection of violence and terrorism and requires a constant and vigilant commitment on the part of political leaders."³⁷ Thus, every candidate for election must demonstrate how s/he intends to resolve the present crisis of terrorism, herdsmen attacks, kidnapping, inter-communal clashes, etc, and to foster peace and security for all citizens.

22. *Education* – Education is a human right. It is the duty of every government to see to the education her citizens. Families and groups should be supported to educate their members. Not to educate the child is to deprive him or her of her a fundamental human right. Several socio-economic problems bedevilling our country are closely linked to the lack of education of our youth. This has

made them easy recruits for socially deviant behaviours like thuggery, terrorism, armed robbery, abduction, child soldiers etc. According to Nigerian Catholic Bishops, the lack of a national philosophy or ideology of education is recognition of a free people's right and the right of their religious institutions, to educate their children as they deem fit. The lack of educational ideology or philosophy is an indication of government willingness to partner with the private sector - Church, voluntary agencies and other qualified groups in education sector.³⁸ Any candidate presenting him or herself for election should be able to present a plan to uplift the educational system of our country. Such plan must show how to implement the policy of compulsory basic education of all children, improve infrastructures in our schools,

end the incessant strikes in our tertiary institutions and also address the many social malaises in our schools, like the widespread culture of examination malpractice and growth of cultism at different levels of education.

23. *Corruption* - Corruption is "'the illicit and non-transparent' provision of private benefits to public officials.'" It also refers to changing or altering the implementation of existing laws, rules, and regulations to "'provide advantages to either state or non-state actors as a result of the illicit and non-transparent provision of private gain to public officials.'"³⁹ Corruption examples range from "government bribery and graft, rigged elections, fraudulent business deals" to "diabolical abuse of occult powers, medical quackery, cheating in school, and even deceiving a lover."⁴⁰ Corruption in these forms

affects virtually all aspects of the society and persons at various levels. It is a cankerworm that has stunted development, economic growth and the building of physical and social infrastructure in Nigeria. In a communiqué after their plenary meeting in September 2012, Nigerian Catholic Bishops noted that “Fighting corruption demands courage and sincerity, and the fight has to start from the top to the lowest cadre.”⁴¹ Any candidate who presents him or herself for election must show proven record of honesty and readiness to fight corruption.

24. *Betrayal of the Social Contract* – According to the Catholic Bishops of Nigeria, there is always a great expectation on the part of the citizens that political leaders in offices will promote good governance that will enhance life economically and promote social well-being by running

a government that is based on justice, fair play, protection against internal and external aggression, provision of important and essential social amenities, social safety nets, etc. Part of the social contract is the preferential option for weak and vulnerable members of the society. Any social policy or programme, therefore, which discriminates against the poor, the sick and other vulnerable members of the society as well as future generations becomes an evil course of action. On the basis of this expectation from the government, citizens surrender their sovereignty to the elected representative. The ceding of a part of citizen’s sovereignty in expectation of good governance becomes a binding social contract that must be protected and respected.

Responsible Civic Activities

25. As patriotic citizens of Nigeria, we are obliged to be actively involved in civic and political activities. These responsibilities include:

- a) Being patriotic and using their votes for the good of Nigeria as opposed to the good of a particular party, group or individual.
- b) Acquire Permanent Voters Card (PVC) to be able to vote.
- c) Vote for candidates who are God fearing, accountable to the electorate for the common good in respect of right of family, property, freedom of religion, security, education, health etc.
- d) Use their votes to make sure that the right persons are elected. Acquire PVC and vote because not to vote may mean the wrong persons being elected.

- e) Choose representatives, who are courageous in defending the truth and justice for all; who are completely honest in fulfilling public and private responsibilities.
- f) Vote according to a well-formed conscience; in accordance with the highest human values without allowing themselves to be pressured or unduly influenced by anyone through bribes, threats, self-interest, etc.
- g) Considering the role of media practitioners in shaping public opinion, they should be careful to disseminate only verified information.
- h) Be careful in the way they accept and disseminate unverified information, especially from social media.⁴²

26. Though Permanent Voter's Card (PVC) is the key to active political

participation during election, voting during election is the second half of the responsibility to decide the moral compass for peace and development, and consequently the strengthening of democracy in Nigeria. The faithful citizens must be encouraged and challenged to get involved in party politics, from the local levels to the national stage. The candidates that eventually become flag-bearers for the various political parties are chosen during party meetings and conventions. If our people do not get involved at this stage, those with other agenda, and possibly not driven by the kind of imagination, vision, and moral reasoning as our Catholic faith offers us, will take over the party structure. Hence, they will continue foist their candidates on the ballot list; and the best we can do is vote for the least of the evils or the best of their best, who may not even be good enough for our basic expectations.

27. *How to Determine a Candidate's Position*

- a. For those aspiring for high offices at the federal levels, such as President, Senate, House of Representatives, and State Governors, it might be easier to determine what they stand for by the past offices they have occupied. These can be sourced from the traditional media, and the internet. The social media can also be helpful. However, considering the preponderance of fake news, and the tendency of political opponents to create unfounded stories during elections, we should endeavour to base our opinions on verified reports.
- b. It is also good to learn about the views of those aspiring for local offices before voting. Yet, as some aspirants for such positions may not have been public figures hitherto, one should be concerned

about their earlier background. We should also critically examine their positions from their manifestoes and campaign offices.

- c. Pay serious attention to public debates which are becoming a common feature before elections, especially those between Governorship and Presidential aspirants. Attention should be paid to the positions candidates stand for, and how they have been able to justify their positions.

Who to Vote for at Elections

28. While we have no intention to advise Christians which candidates to cast their votes for at elections, we have a moral obligation to spell out what to look for in candidates vying for elective posts. As enunciated above, Christians must always be guided in all their actions by the dictates of the

well-formed conscience that perceives the proper relationship among moral goods. Thus, Christians cannot vote for candidates that support intrinsic evil actions and a situation where all candidates hold and promote intrinsic evil actions. In the unlikely event that all candidates hold and promote evil actions or principles, Christians have an obligation to boycott election. In such situation, we cannot make a choice between two evils or choose the lesser evil, except where there is a strong conviction that the lesser evil is more likely not going to advance the flawed policy and more likely to pursue other authentic human goods.

29. A morally mature and prudent person, in this case, a voter, must distinguish between sharing in another person's intention – desires, choices, and evil means (*formal cooperation*), and sharing in an action but not approving the intention (*material cooperation*).⁴³ This

is important because actions have consequences. The political choices faced by Christians have attendant costs on the general well-being of every member of the society and on the salvation of the individuals and their ability to practice their Christian beliefs.⁴⁴

Considerations before Casting Vote

30. How To Vote

- a. Rank the different candidates for each of the offices according to how they fare on the important issues outlined above.
- b. Give preference to candidates who do stand for the issues outlined and do not contradict them.
- c. Where the available candidates do not fare well on the different issues, choose candidates that are likely to do least harm.

31. How Not To Vote

- a. While one may have political affiliations, one shall not vote a particular party or candidate for tribal and ethnic reasons.
- b. Merely religious and denominational affiliation is insufficient to determine one's vote. Any candidate for elections must have basic positive values to promote.
- a) One shall not vote for a candidate or party because one has been financially induced to vote thus.

5

**EXTRA VIGILANCE AND
HYPOCRISY IN POLITICS**

32. Biblically, we are warned not to put our trust in any mortal least we be disappointed (Ps 146.3). A current dilemma in the political history of Nigeria is the inability of political actors to deliver on their promises. Nigerians are constant victims of unmet hopes and failed promises. This should not however discourage us from participating actively in political life. We are people of hope and there is no need to become despondent or cynical because of our past bitter experiences in politics. Rather there is need for extra vigilance in dealing with prospective candidates and public office holders. We should not be carried away by their pre-election

promises and we must try to match their words with their actions. There is the need to probe their antecedence and profile them before casting our vote for them.

33. We must not allow to be deceived by emotional and sentimental appeals to religion or tribal or primordial blackmail. We not allow politicians to manipulate or influence us by such uncritical and non-factual tactics. So, beyond providing our people a charter of demands to politicians, electors should demand and organise pre-election town hall meetings with candidates vying for elective positions. Voters should keep notes so that these pre-election encounters and notes shall serve as compass and barometers after elections between citizens and their elected representatives.

Sectionalism and Partiality in Politics

34. Nigerians have suffered in the hands of politicians that extol the vices of sectionalism and partiality. The bitter civil war that ended the lives of more than one million Nigerians and the sectarian violence and wilful destruction of lives by religious bigots and ethnic militants are the consequences of sectional politics and partiality in politics.
35. We cannot afford a replay of the constant threat and wanton destruction of lives and properties by proponents of sectional politics and their foot soldiers. Political thuggery and the violence associated with politicking in Nigeria are all fallouts of such politics. We must therefore shun politicians that have tendencies for such or whose antecedence points to such inclination.
36. Public offices are public trust. We cannot afford to have politicians who

will not operate equal opportunity policy but resort to discriminating tactics and victimisation of those outside their parties or circle of loyalists or their religious and ethnic groups.

37. A politician with sectional tendency will most likely be unjust in the exercise of the trust reposed in him/her; and s/he also has the tendency to disrespect and violate democratic values and equal opportunity in the allocation of the resources and public offices. Merit and competence, capacity and character will all be sacrificed on the altar of nepotism and favouritism.
38. The consequences of sectionalism in government are insecurity, ethnic tension, mutual suspicion and sectarian violence and the disruption of public peace. There are not enabling environment for good governance or attraction for investors.

Saying 'No' to Vote Buying

39. Vote buying is a common practice in Nigeria. According to Nigerian Catholic bishops, a faithful citizen does not sell or buy votes.⁴⁵ Significantly, it is wrong for Christians, ditto anybody, to allow money or other forms of inducement to influence how they cast their votes instead of following the dictate of their consciences. The CBCN emphatically states, "...selling one's vote or casting it for shortsighted (sic) gain is offensive before God and man."⁴⁶
40. Candidates are free to canvas for votes not by inducing the electorate with money or putting them under undue pressure. Instead of resorting to vote buying, politicians must learn the act of vote bargain. Vote bargaining is a situation where promises and commitment to provide certain social infrastructures are extracted from prospective candidates pre-election

and that becomes pre-condition for being voted for at election. Where such promises and commitments are not honoured, the electorate have the constitutional right and obligation to recall such representatives if they win elections, or vote them out during subsequent elections.

41. The electorate must be taught and enlightened to appreciate the strength and power of their individual and collective votes. There is obviously what is called ballot/voter's power and it is the most potent power if the electorate know how to take advantage of this power.

CONCLUSION

42. As Christians, we are people of hope. We shall not give in to despair but trust in Divine Providence to direct all of our affairs as we approach the forthcoming elections. We are confident that God will take us successfully through the electioneering periods.

We entrust our country to the patronage of Our Lady Queen of Nigeria.

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 - i. *The action is the cooperating party is either neutral or good, but surely not immoral "in itself";*

- ii. *There are proportionally grave reasons for the cooperation;*
- iii. *The cooperating party has not resigned him/herself to fate but is constantly looking for ways to help the other party stop such illicit actions, even if not immediately or at every occasion of the 'sin'.*

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